The Eighties

Erich Honecker's New Year's message began in familiar fashion with promises for better times ahead in the 'struggle for peace and socialism', and so on. 'We do it responsibly, objectively, and with well-founded optimism.' Even though such addresses typically conveyed an inoffensive message, he touched upon Afghanistan saying, 'the party and state leadership and the people of the GDR support the measures taken by the Soviet Union at the request of the Afghan party and state leadership to guarantee peace and security'. By this point, the debacle in Kabul was severely draining the Soviet Union's economic resources.

On the ground, Babrak Karmal was installed as ruler, backed by Soviet troops, just as Mujahideen rebels – financed by the CIA – launched military operations designed to bog down the Russians. Though never a cause he wished to champion, Honecker defended Moscow in Pravda by declaring it:

laughable that those who are themselves to blame for the deterioration in the international situation are trying to link it to events in Afghanistan. The GDR is in complete solidarity with the Afghan people's struggle and is firmly on the side of the Soviet Union, which is giving them international assistance.1

The tense atmosphere over Afghanistan, which was turning into a Vietnam-like quagmire, prompted chancellor Schmidt to call-off his planned meeting with Honecker (rescheduled for August). The news was muted in the GDR media, which focused on several domestic events that winter, including Honecker's attendance at the 30th-anniversary celebrations for the Ministry of State Security. In an address to officers, he praised their 'courageous fighters on the invisible front'. Newspapers respectfully reprinted the speech, together with a picture of pint-sized Mielke, clad in a braided white